

IMPERIAL FIREPOWER

THE BATTLE OF OMDURMAN

The battle fought between General Herbert Kitchener's Anglo-Egyptian army and the Muslim Mahdists at Omdurman, in Sudan on 2 September 1898, was an overwhelming victory for European industrial technology over a determined African army of superior numbers but limited firepower.

As *Sirdar* (commander-in-chief) of the British-officered Egyptian army, Kitchener was entrusted with avenging the death of General Gordon at the hands of Sudanese Mahdists. The Mahdists were in revolt against British-supported Egyptian rule, and had killed Gordon in 1885 at Khartoum; tactically, Britain also wanted to deter the ambitions of the rival French in Sudan.

Kitchener's army of 8,000 British and 18,000 Egyptian troops advanced down the Nile, accompanied by river gunboats carrying supplies and heavy equipment and providing extra firepower. The land forces were equipped with field artillery as well as 40 Maxim guns, each capable of firing 600 rounds per minute. The infantry, meanwhile, carried the latest Lee Metford and Lee Enfield rifles, rapid-fire bolt-action weapons with box magazines. Some of the riverborne guns were also provided with shells containing Lyddite, a new high explosive that would later be used in World War I.

The Mahdist leader Khalifa Abdullah al-Taashi waited at Omdurman, near Khartoum. About one third of his army of over 50,000 men had rifles, though often without adequate or appropriate ammunition. The rest relied on spears and swords, still perfectly serviceable weapons at a time when European infantry still practiced the bayonet charge.

On 1 September British cavalry scouts made contact with the Mahdist army. Kitchener took up a defensive position on the bank of the Nile, with his infantry in the centre and cavalry on the flanks. At dawn the following day some 8,000 Mahdist warriors,

dressed in white and flourishing banners, made a frontal assault on the defensive perimeter. Their charge across the open plain was met by the fire of field artillery and gunboats and then, as they drew closer, of Maxim guns and rifles. As infantry were to find during the carnage of World War I, an advance into such density of fire from these new weapons was near-suicidal. Not a single warrior reached the defensive line.

RIFLES AND DISCIPLINE

The majority of the Mahdist forces, however, remained in concealed positions around the Anglo-Egyptian camp. When Kitchener's troops left their defensive perimeter and advanced over the body-strewn ground towards Omdurman, they entered a trap. The 21st Lancers, with young war correspondent Winston Churchill in their ranks, inadvertently rode into the midst of several thousand Mahdists hidden in a dry streambed, and suffered 61 casualties. Potentially more serious was the fate of General Hector Macdonald's infantry brigade, caught in the open by some 15,000 Mahdists emerging from hiding, but the 3,000-strong brigade held off the attackers with disciplined rifle fire until reinforcements arrived.

Kitchener's forces advanced relentlessly on Omdurman while it was bombarded with Lyddite shells. By the end of the day the remnants of the Mahdist army had withdrawn, and the town was in British hands. Around 10,000 Mahdists died, compared with only 48 Anglo-Egyptian troops – a striking display of the killing power of European military technology.

